

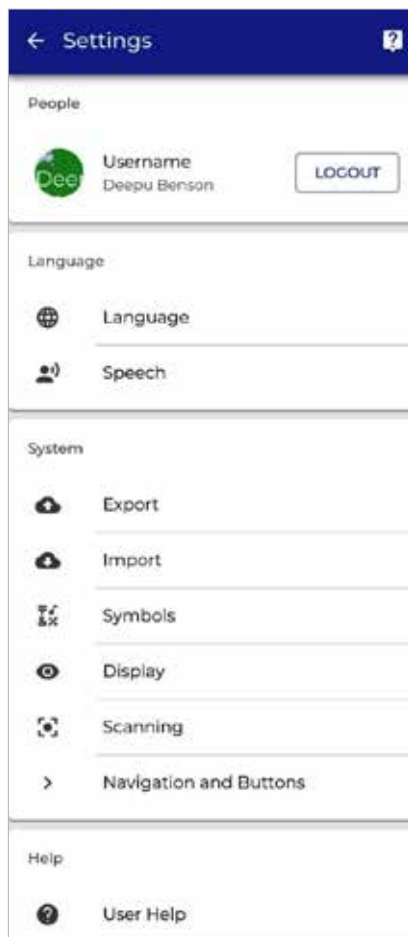


Figure 1: The screenshot of the *Settings* page in the Cboard app

Cboard: Designed for special education

Cboard is one such highly useful free and open source software, designed as an augmentative and alternative communication (AAC) software. It allows users with speech and language impairments to communicate using symbols and text-to-speech (TTS). This cross-platform software is licensed under the MIT License. The GitHub repository for Cboard is available at <https://github.com/cboard-org>, and the English version of the Cboard information website is available at www.cboard.io/en.

Cboard offers a wide variety of graphical images for users to choose from, enabling them to construct fairly complex sentences by selecting these

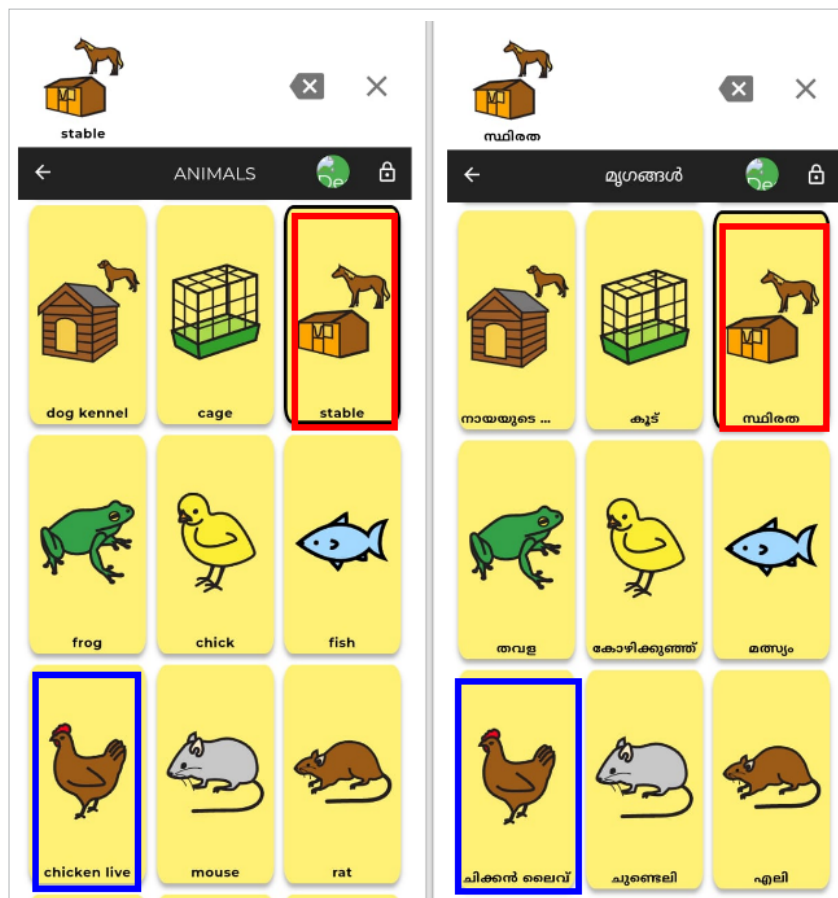


Figure 2: A board showing images and names of animals in English and Malayalam

images. The application then reads out the sentences in the user's chosen language. Cboard supports both web and mobile platforms.

In my opinion, a touchscreen laptop is the ideal device for training with Cboard, as individuals with neurodevelopmental disabilities often struggle with poor eye-hand coordination and motor skills. However, a standard laptop or smartphone can also be used for training with Cboard. Figure 1 shows a screenshot of the *Settings* page in the Cboard app, where you can change the language for displaying and reading text, among other options.

What surprised me when I first encountered the Cboard software was the lack of Malayalam language support. This was unexpected, considering that Kerala is a state known

for excelling in education and human resource development in India. Despite this, Malayalam was not supported until a group of volunteers, including myself, made a request. The Cboard development team responded promptly, and Malayalam support was added. As of writing this article, the following Indian languages are supported: Bengali, Hindi, Malayalam, and Nepali. It was also surprising that versions of Cboard in widely spoken languages such as Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Odia, Gujarati, and Marathi were absent. However, before making a request to the Cboard development team, please ensure that the language you need for training is not already supported.

It's work in progress

Let me share my experience working with the Malayalam version of the